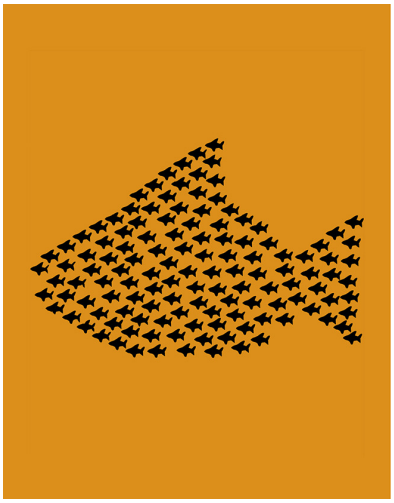


A POPULATION OF POPULATIONS

METAPOPULATIONS

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Ilkka Hanski (1953–2016)

BEFORE

1931 In the US, geneticist Sewall Wright explores the influence of genetic factors on species populations.

1933 In Australia, ecologist Alexander Nicholson and physicist Victor Bailey develop their model of population dynamics to describe the host–parasite relationship.

1954 In *The Distribution and Abundance of Animals*, Australian ecologists Herbert Andrewartha and Charles Birch challenge the idea that species populations are controlled by density alone.

AFTER

2007 American ecologist James Petranka links metapopulation theory to the metamorphosis stages of amphibians.

A metapopulation is a combination of separate, local populations of the same species. The term was coined by American ecologist Richard Levins in 1969 to describe how insect pest populations rise and fall on farm fields.